to stop American overflights. The second antiaircraft division, under the command of Major General Mikhail Tokarenko, came to Cuba from Ukraine. Its Soviet designation was Dnipropetrovsk Antiaircraft Division no. 11—in Cuba it was given the number 12. Both divisions were armed with S-75 Desna (in US terminology, SA 2 Guideline) surface-to-air missiles (SAMs) capable of reaching high altitudes and shooting down U-2 aircraft. The Dnipropetrovsk Division, which took up its position in western Cuba, arrived on the island in July, while the Volgograd Division reached the eastern part of the island in August.[4]

The first medium-range R-12 missiles that the S-75 Desna rockets were supposed to protect from American overflights arrived in Cuba on September 9 aboard the *Omsk*, a Japanese-built cargo ship delivered to the USSR the previous year at a cost of $3.5 million. The *Omsk* was equipped with twelve medium cranes as well as one light and one heavy gibbet, which helped speed up the loading process in the ship's five cargo holds. The *Omsk* brought in six 22-meter-long R-12 missiles and 166 pieces of machinery. Altogether 2,200 tons of missiles and equipment were unloaded from the cargo bay once the ship arrived in Cuba.[5]

The R-12 missiles delivered by the *Omsk* belonged to Missile Regiment no. 637 from the Lithuanian town of Plungė. Its commander, the forty-one-year-old colonel Ivan Sidorov, was a late arrival to Operation Anadyr and was not appointed to his new position until late July, when his predecessor, Colonel V. V. Kolesnichenko, asked the commanders to relieve him of the overseas duty for family reasons. Marshal Biriuzov's deputy, General Tolubko, who was in charge of the selection and shipment of missile regiments to Cuba, sent a special plane to Lithuania to bring both Kolesnichenko and Sidorov, who then commanded a different regiment, to Moscow to attend a meeting of the military council of the Strategic Missile Troops. Kolesnichenko was called in first and dismissed only a few minutes later. By the look on his face, Sidorov realized that he had been demoted. When Tolubko called Sidorov in, he asked whether he would be prepared to embark on a special government assignment. No details were provided, but Sidorov responded in the affirmative, asking only for permission to take his wife along. The request was granted.[6]